

Chapter 66_1: Blazing Fire

The moment her toes touched the crimson mud, it felt as if hundreds of people were gripping her legs, desperately dragging her downward. Countless bloody hands tore at her body. Ning Fuyi closed her eyes and held her breath, allowing those icy hands to grope around her body.

The mud water soon covered her ears and nose, and her surroundings fell silent. After the silence, painful clamoring suddenly erupted. Countless men, women, elderly, and children wailed and screamed beside her ears. Ning Fuyi struggled to open her eyes, and all she could see were unclear phantoms.

These phantoms were all the vengeful spirits in this tiger's den¹, layer upon layer crowded together, roaming throughout the cave. Pain continuously tore them apart, then they drifted and reassembled.

Though they had no flesh and blood, the cruelty of torn flesh and splattered blood could be heard from their screams and ravings. These vengeful spirits, who died from suffering, were trapped in this cave for lifetime after lifetime, unable to perish, unable to transcend.

Ning Fuyi's head throbbed from the noise. She raised her divine sword to strike at the vengeful spirits, but it was like cutting water with a blade—it had no effect whatsoever. The surrounding walls were all reflective black rock, hard as black iron, and there was no point in thinking about breaking through.

She didn't have that kind of power anyway.

So she gritted her teeth, covered her ears, and stepped deeper into the cave with unsteady footsteps.

There were simply too many vengeful spirits around. From time to time, vengeful spirits passed through her body, as if she were suddenly immersed in ice water, then pulled out and returned to the blazingly hot cave like being roasted by fire. Ning Fuyi desperately used her immortal power to protect herself, but it couldn't withstand the erosion of vengeful energy, and the scenery before her eyes soon began to distort.

"Wenzhu!" she shouted loudly. "Liu Wenzhu!"

No one responded to her. Ning Fuyi grew increasingly anxious in her heart. No longer caring about the bone-piercing vengeful spirits, she simply covered her face with her sleeve and began running quickly. One vengeful spirit after another passed through her body, alternating between ice and fire, making her steps increasingly unsteady.

After stumbling through a wetland where mud water submerged her feet, she finally caught a glimpse of a piece of blue clothing hem among a cluster of drifting vengeful spirits. She shouted Liu Wenzhu's name and ran desperately to her side, stumbling to her knees.

The vengeful spirits around them were still competing to cling to them and feed. Ning Fuyi felt violent energy surge in her heart. She drew her divine sword with her backhand and thrust it into the earth, quickly forming hand seals with both hands. Then she shouted fiercely, and the divine sword burst forth with pale pink blinding radiance, like rippling wind waves, turning the surrounding vengeful spirits into ash.

She reached out to pull up the limp Liu Wenzhu, hurriedly checking her breathing. When her fingertips felt the weak airflow being exhaled, the irritation in her heart lessened somewhat.

Fortunately, she had arrived in time. If she had been half an hour later, what she would have seen would definitely have been a dried corpse that had been drained.

However, even though she was alive, Liu Wenzhu's current condition was far from optimistic. Her originally white skin like congealed fat now showed a bluish-black color from within, her red lips were stained with blood, and her hands and feet were ice cold. Ning Fuyi raised her hand to summon immortal power, continuously channeling it into Liu Wenzhu's body.

After an unknown amount of time, the bluish-black color on that face finally faded somewhat. The woman's body swayed and she coughed up a mouthful of fresh blood, then began breathing heavily as if she had suffered extreme fright.

"Help me, help me..." She kept mumbling deliriously, trying to break free from Ning Fuyi. Her almond-shaped eyes overflowed with tears that fell drop by drop.

"Wenzhu, it's me!" Seeing that she was scared out of her wits, Ning Fuyi quickly called out loudly to bring back her consciousness. After three consecutive calls, Liu Wenzhu finally stopped shouting and peered through her tears to make out Ning Fuyi's face.

When she finally saw clearly who was in front of her, she bit her lip, opened her arms wide to embrace Ning Fuyi's neck, and sobbed in her shoulder.

Even her fear was gentle and quiet, making one's nose tingle with emotion.

However, Liu Wenzhu hadn't cried for long when she suddenly remembered something. She pushed Ning Fuyi away forcefully, and with her nose red from crying, her almond eyes filled with anger: "What are you doing here! Who brought you here!"

Seeing that she wasn't dead, Ning Fuyi temporarily put her heart at ease and sat down heavily in the mud, wiping away the grime that she hadn't cleaned off her face earlier.

"No one harmed me, I was just careless myself," Ning Fuyi lied with a calm expression. "When I came down, I saw you unconscious here, so I called out to wake you up."

"Careless?" Liu Wenzhu naturally didn't believe it. She gripped Ning Fuyi's arm and said, "You never came to Eastern Mountain with me, so how could you be careless! Don't lie to me!"

Seeing her persistence, Ning Fuyi had no choice but to forcibly change the subject: "Do you know what place this is, and how did you fall in?"

Liu Wenzhu shook her head.

So Ning Fuyi told her everything she had seen and heard at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, as well as what had happened after coming to Eastern Mountain. She only omitted the fact that she had intentionally jumped into the tiger's den, covering it up as accidentally losing her footing while searching for her.

"Li Zhao'an?" Even someone with Liu Wenzhu's good temper couldn't help but feel hatred. She gripped a piece of rock with her fingertips to suppress her anger, actually crushing the rock to powder.

"What exactly did we ever owe her! It would be one thing if she usually targeted us, but to actually make such a vicious move, trying to kill us!" Liu Wenzhu's eyes were red with anger. "It's also my fault for not knowing that fellow disciples could be so treacherous, letting my guard down around her!"

"It's my fault," Ning Fuyi said quietly.

In her previous life, Li Zhao'an had indeed brought her considerable pain and humiliation, and she detested Li Zhao'an extremely. But perhaps because she could never compare to Li Zhao'an, Li Zhao'an had never really done anything to her.

To her, the other party was just an annoying passerby in her long life, so she truly hadn't thought that in this life, it would be Li Zhao'an who would cause her to fall into the tiger's den.

Others might know what they were facing, know where their enemies were, but she didn't. What she faced was always the inescapable "predestined fate." What caused her to lose family and friends wasn't any particular person, but destiny.

It was as if she didn't deserve to be loved, destined to always be losing.

Whether in her past life or this life, aside from becoming stronger, she could find no other solution.

The vengeful spirits around them gathered more and more. The divine sword's power couldn't last that long—its light gradually dimmed, and the vengeful spirits collided with each other, greedily wanting to "devour" the fresh humans before their eyes.

A vengeful spirit had already touched the hem of Liu Wenzhu's clothing. Liu Wenzhu was so frightened she nearly fainted, and weak flames appeared in her palms, driving that vengeful spirit away.

She was trembling with fear, tightly hugging Ning Fuyi's shoulders, pressed close together with her.

The vengeful energy was truly too dense. Ning Fuyi's vision kept producing terrifying double images, and those vengeful spirits came one after another before her to cry and complain, giving her splitting headaches that made her drowsy with pain.

Liu Wenzhu beside her was even worse off.

"Yiyi, let's talk. Don't sleep—if you sleep, you'll never wake up again." Liu Wenzhu leaned weakly against her shoulder, speaking softly.

Neither of them had any extra energy to discuss other things. Before their eyes was only one problem—death.

"Alright." Ning Fuyi spoke. She squeezed out some more immortal power and channeled it into the divine sword, making it continue to drive away the vengeful spirits.

"When you came in, did you hear what those vengeful spirits were saying?" Liu Wenzhu asked.

"No," Ning Fuyi answered deliberately.

Liu Wenzhu made an "mm" sound, seeming to feel relieved.

"I still remember when you were little, you were about the size of a monkey. The youngest disciples in the sect were teenagers, and seeing you were such a little thing, no one played with you." Liu Wenzhu actually laughed under extreme fear, speaking gently.

"Yes," Ning Fuyi also laughed along with her, waving her hand to shatter a vengeful spirit. "I was spoiled by Ning Changfeng back then and loved to cry. Whenever I was unhappy I would cry, and I couldn't understand why no one liked me."

From childhood, she could feel others' disgust and disdain toward her. Although children don't understand anything, their sensitive hearts are no less than adults'.

"Fortunately you came later. I still remember the day we met—you were unwilling to join Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. I broke Ning Changfeng's cup, and we were both punished to kneel in the ancestral hall, facing each other and crying for half the day." Ning Fuyi opened memories that had been sealed for many years, and many long-forgotten events surged into her heart.

What seemed like ordinary days back then now felt both sweet and bitter when remembered, so bitter that it made one's throat dry.

From that day on, Ning Fuyi had her first friend.

Footnotes:

¹ Tiger's den (虎穴) - In this context, refers to a dangerous place or trap, literally an underground cavern that serves as a prison for vengeful spirits.